spoke his mind—that he was an honest man. Such people are rare in politics now. No one ever said they didn't like him.

When the Bharat Jodo Yatra reached the Dholpur area, Rahul ji met a group of women. He listened and responded to each of them. Sushila Bai, a prominent activist of the Right to Information movement, also met him. While narrating her experience, she told me that she told Rahul ji that the pension of the elderly should be increased, because who lived for seventy-five years waiting for their pension to be increased? Rahul ji listened to her and asked Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot to increase the pension, then turned to her and said in a humorous tone, 'Don't worry, you will live for seventy-five years.'

I am happy that I participated in this historic padyatra, that I got the opportunity to have a long discussion with Rahul Gandhi ji and a chance to walk about 8 kilometres with him. There was an ideological and theoretical conversation between Rahul ji and me. We discussed the increasing communalism, violence, politics of fear and hatred, Dalit atrocities, political participation of Dalits, tribals and the backward classes, and the Scheduled Castes Sub-Allocation & Tribal Sub-Allocation Act (as passed in Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan). Rahul Gandhi also asked me about my views on the caste census and said that he did not understand why Dalit tribals joined the RSS. Rahul ji described his Bharat Jodo Yatra as a spiritual journey rather than a political one, and stated that his aim was to establish love by eliminating fear from people's hearts.

After meeting him I can say this—talking to him while walking with him was a pleasant learning experience. I feel Rahul ji listens deeply to every person and expresses his views with complete ease. I can undoubtedly say that through the Bharat Jodo Yatra he has established himself as a public leader who truly lives in the hearts of the people.

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1 Bhanwar Meghwanshi, *I Could Not Be Hindu: The Story of a Dalit in the RSS*, Navayana, 2020.